

Chapter 1 – The Eternal & Temporary Dharmas of the Jīva

In Śrī Godruma in Navadvīpa-maṇḍala, Śrī Premadāsa Paramahansa Bābājī lived in Pradyumna-kuṇja, chanting two hundred thousand holy names every day and reading the Prema-vivarta of Śrī Jagadānanda. One day a sannyāsī of Śaṅkara's school came to him, having found no spiritual satisfaction after years of study and renunciation. The sight of a Vaiṣṇava sādhu chanting “Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, Prabhu Nityānanda!” in tears had drawn his heart to the Vaiṣṇavas, and so he came to take shelter of Bābājī.

The sannyāsī asked: What is the true constitutional dharma of the jīvas, and why do different teachers explain it in such diverse ways? Bābājī explained that an object is called a vastu and its eternal nature (svabhāva) is its nitya-dharma. Through contact with other objects the nature of an object becomes distorted; this acquired nature is called nisarga and takes the place of the true nature, just as the solidity of ice takes the place of the liquidity of water. The acquired nature arises from a cause and ceases along with it; it is naimittika-dharma (the occasional function). Those who lack true knowledge of objects mistake temporary dharma for eternal dharma.

Śrī Bhagavān is the only real Entity (vāstava-vastu); the jīva is His separated part and māyā is His energy. Knowledge of the interrelationship of these three is pure knowledge (śuddha-jñāna). According to the instruction of Śrīman Mahāprabhu (Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Madhya-līlā 20.108, 117), the jīva is by his constitutional nature the eternal servant of Śrī Kṛṣṇa. Kṛṣṇa is like the sun of the spiritual realm and the jīvas are like the atomic particles of its light: they are one with Him in their spiritual nature, but differ in that He is infinite and they are infinitesimal. The eternal dharma of the jīva is therefore kṛṣṇa-dāsyā, service to Kṛṣṇa.

The jīvas are a manifestation of Kṛṣṇa's marginal energy (taṭasthā-śakti): their nature is spiritual, but they can come under the control of māyā, whereas Bhagavān is her controller. The jīva is simultaneously different and non-different from Bhagavān (bhedābheda-prakāśa), and the eternal difference is predominant. When the jīva forgets his service to Kṛṣṇa – and this fall does not take place within material time (anādi-bahirmukha) – he is subjected to the tyranny of māyā, his nitya-dharma becomes perverted, and naimittika-dharma is manifested. Nitya-dharma is one, indivisible, and faultless in all situations; naimittika-dharma assumes many forms according to circumstances and the opinions of those who describe it.

Chapter 2 – The Nitya-dharma of the Jīva is Pure and Eternal

The next day Sannyāsī Ṭhākura asked: If the jīva is infinitesimal, how can his eternal dharma be complete and pure? And if his function is formed at the moment he is constituted, how can it be eternal? Bābājī replied that the jīvas emanate from Kṛṣṇa like sparks from a fire, and just as each spark has the power of the whole fire, each jīva can display the full function of consciousness. The nitya-dharma of the jīva is prema, transcendental love for Kṛṣṇa, whose nature is service.

The jīva exists in two states: the pure (śuddha-avasthā) and the conditioned (baddha-avasthā). In the pure state he considers himself Kṛṣṇa's servant; in contact with māyā his identity is covered by the subtle and gross bodies, and his prema is manifested pervertedly as happiness and distress, attachment and aversion, and sense enjoyment. The dharma of the conditioned state is naimittika. The religions of the world may be divided into anitya-dharma, which accepts neither Īśvara nor the eternality of the soul; naimittika-dharma, which accepts them but seeks Īśvara's mercy only by provisional methods; and nitya-dharma, which strives for the service of Bhagavān out of unalloyed prema. Nitya-dharma is one, whatever it is called in different countries; its ideal is vaiṣṇava-dharma as taught by Śrī Caitanya, and the degree of vaiṣṇava-dharma in any religion is the measure of its purity.

Asked about advaita-siddhi, Bābājī first offered obeisances to Śaṅkarācārya: he is Mahādeva-Śaṅkara himself, the guru of the Vaiṣṇavas, who restored the authority of the Vedas when śūnyavāda prevailed and laid the foundation on which the Vaiṣṇava ācāryas built. Up to the point of liberation there is great agreement between them; Śaṅkara was merely silent about what the jīva attains after liberation. Prema, however, requires the separate existence of two transcendental entities. Māyāvāda, which regards the states of prema as illusory, is therefore opposed to the Vedas according to the Vaiṣṇavas.

When the sannyāsī wished to give up his dress, Bābājī said that he gives no instructions about external dress: when the dharma of the heart is purified, the external is set right by itself, and one should not adopt monkey renunciation (markaṭa-vairāgya). To the second question he replied that the “creation” of the jīva refers to material time; in spiritual time (cit-kāla), which is an eternal present, both the jīva and his dharma are eternal. This cannot be understood by logic, but by spiritual meditation. He instructed him to chant hari-nāma constantly, for nāma-saṅkīrtana is the best of the nine forms of bhakti and, chanted without offenses, bestows the treasure of prema. That day Sannyāsī Ṭhākura experienced a taste (ruci) for hari-nāma.

Chapter 3 – Naimittika-dharma is to be relinquished

One night, while Sannyāsī Mahārāja was chanting hari-nāma, the transcendental form of Śrī Māyāpura appeared before him. In the morning he threw his ekadaṇḍa staff into the river, put on tulasī beads and tilaka, and Paramahansa Bābājī named him Vaiṣṇava dāsa. That afternoon one of those present, the brāhmaṇa and zamindar Kālīdāsa Lāhirī, asked: The dharma-śāstras declare the brāhmaṇas to be the highest caste and rites such as sandhyā-vandanā to be their nitya-karma; why is the behavior of the Vaiṣṇavas contrary to them? Vaiṣṇava dāsa replied.

Human nature has two tendencies: vaidhī, which follows the rules of śāstra, and rāgānugā, which follows the soul's spontaneous attraction to Kṛṣṇa. Rāgānugā is the unalloyed nature of the jīva, but jīvas bound by māyā do not know it, and it is awakened only by the mercy of sādhus; therefore Bhagavān mercifully manifested the śāstras and the path of rules. Śāstra gives different instructions according to eligibility (adhikāra) for karma, jñāna, and prema. Karma that does not lead to jñāna, and karma and jñāna that do not lead to bhakti, are cheating processes; in reality they are steps on a single staircase leading to the temple of bhakti. For the proper performance of karma the śāstras established varṇāśrama-dharma; varṇa is determined by nature, qualities, and activities, not by birth alone.

The words nitya and naimittika are applied to karma only in a conventional, figurative sense. Sandhyā-vandanā is called nitya-karma because it remotely points toward nitya-dharma; the only real nitya-karma of the jīva is kṛṣṇa-prema. Varṇāśrama, aṣṭāṅga-yoga, sāṅkhya-jñāna, and tapasya are all naimittika, because the jīva would not need them if he were not bound – and the same applies to the superiority of the brāhmaṇas and to their sannyāsa. According to Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam (7.9.10), a bhakta born among dog-eaters is superior to a brāhmaṇa with the twelve qualities who is averse to Bhagavān. Of those who are spiritually unawakened, the brāhmaṇas are the best; those who are spiritually awakened are called Vaiṣṇavas. Their behavior is different, yet it does not oppose the aim of the smṛti.

Naimittika-dharma is incomplete, because it is only a means to an end; adulterated, because it yields extraneous results such as the brāhmaṇa's pride, mystic powers, mukti, and bhukti; impermanent, because it changes with every birth; and fit to be rejected. Vaiṣṇava-dharma is the nitya-dharma of the jīva. A Vaiṣṇava accepts the rules of the śāstras when they are favorable to his hari-bhajana and rejects them when they are unfavorable. Lāhirī Mahāśaya accepted Vaiṣṇava dāsa in his heart as his guru.

Chapter 4 – Vaiṣṇava-dharma is Nitya-dharma

When Lāhirī Mahāśaya was frightened by a snake at his door, Vaiṣṇava dāsa Bābājī reminded him that the body is not eternal and that nothing can harm it without Kṛṣṇa's will; a mind agitated by fear cannot be fixed on the lotus feet of Śrī Hari. He then explained that two dharmas go by the name vaiṣṇava-dharma. The pure one (śuddha) is one, has four divisions according to rasa – dāsyā, sakhyā, vātsalyā, and mādhyā – and is nitya-dharma. The adulterated one (viddha) is mixed either with karma, where Viṣṇu is merely part of the ritual, or with jñāna, where five deities are worshiped (pañcopāsanā) as a means to the featureless brahma.

People have three tendencies toward the Absolute Truth: toward brahma, toward Paramātmā, and toward Bhagavān. Bhagavān is the highest tattva and the basis of the other two (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.2.11). The dharmas that arise from the tendencies toward brahma and Paramātmā are naimittika; only unalloyed bhāgavata-dharma is eternal. Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu taught three fundamental principles: sambandha (one's relationship with Bhagavān), abhidheya (the means), and prayojana (the goal).

Sambandha includes Bhagavān, the jīvas, and the material world. Bhagavān is one, endowed with all energies; the effulgence of His limbs is brahma, His partial expansion in the world is Paramātmā, in Vaikuṇṭha He is Nārāyaṇa, and in Goloka Vṛndāvana He is Śrī Kṛṣṇa. His form is sac-cid-ānanda and has nothing to do with matter. His energy is manifested as internal (cit), marginal (jīva), and māyā. The jīvas are atomic entities of pure consciousness, either liberated or bound; māyā is the external energy, the bodies are her creation, and the universe is a prison, not the jīva's eternal home. Without sambandha-jñāna no one becomes a pure Vaiṣṇava; the bhāva of those who consider themselves one with brahma is only a pretense. No learning is required for this – the guru imparts this knowledge by his words and conduct.

Abhidheya is sādhana-bhakti. Bhakti has three stages: sādhana, bhāva, and prema. Sādhana has nine forms (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 7.5.23) and two kinds: vaidhī, impelled by the rules of śāstra, and rāgānugā, impelled by spontaneous love. Bābājī determined vaidhī-bhakti for Lāhirī and instructed him to chant the Hare Kṛṣṇa mahā-mantra without offenses, for there is no difference between the name and its possessor, and nāma-bhajana includes all nine forms. Lāhirī began to chant two lakhs of names daily and became a Vaiṣṇava. Prayojana is kṛṣṇa-prema: from steady sādhana bhāva arises, and fully developed bhāva is prema – the eternal function, wealth, and goal of the jīva.

Chapter 5 – Vaidhī-bhakti is Nitya- not Naimittika-dharma

Lāhirī Mahāśaya's sons in Śāntipura were worried about the family's reputation, so the younger of them, the learned Devīdāsa Vidyāratna, came to Godruma to bring his father home. He asked him to perform sandhyā-vandanā and the other duties of a brāhmaṇa at home, these being his nitya-dharma. His father replied that what his son calls nitya-dharma is naimittika; the only nitya-dharma is hari-bhakti.

Devīdāsa asked how sandhyā-vandanā differs from the practices of vaidhī-bhakti. Lāhirī explained that the rites of karma-kāṇḍa are performed for the sake of liberation, whereas hari-bhajana has no ulterior motive and its fruit is prema. Externally no difference is visible; it lies in niṣṭhā. Ekādaśī removes the sins of the karmīs, but strengthens the bhakti of the bhaktas: the bhakta obtains the principal result, while the karmī is caught in the secondary ones – bhukti and mukti. The śāstras praise the secondary results in order to bring the ignorant to pious deeds and to the sādhus; a person's faith corresponds to his adhikāra, and therefore it is not proper to criticize anyone.

Vaiṣṇava dāsa Bābājī told Devīdāsa, who aspired for mukti, that he too had studied Śaṅkara's commentary for fifteen years before realizing that it was a newly fashioned system; the true explanation of the Vedānta-sūtra was given by Śrī Caitanya to Sārvabhauma. The father refused to return to a house opposed to bhakti. Asked why the nine activities of bhakti are not also naimittika, he explained that of those who strive for a higher goal, only those devoted to Īśvara (īśānugata) truly seek paramārtha: for them the jīvas are His servants even after liberation. Those who hanker for mystic powers subordinate Īśvara to the law of karma, and the jñānīs merely imagine His form and then discard it.

The worship of the Deity in vaiṣṇava-dharma is nitya-dharma: Bhagavān's sac-cid-ānanda form is revealed in the pure consciousness of the jīva and, by the power of bhakti, is manifested in the Deity. The jñānīs see in the Deity only a material statue. The external procedure is the same, the faith entirely different – and with this Devīdāsa's greatest doubt was dispelled. The next day a Kāzī came, a descendant of Chānd Kāzī, and explained that the soul (rūh) is purified by the development of love (īśhqh), that the relationship between servant and Lord is eternal, and that the Lord has no material form. “Gaurāṅga is our life,” he said.

Chapter 6 – Nitya-dharma, race & caste

Devīdāsa Vidyāratna, convinced that only born brāhmaṇas can attain the highest goal, brought to Godruma about a hundred paṇḍitas headed by Kṛṣṇa Cūḍāmaṇi, who reproached the Vaiṣṇavas: “Why do you associate with Muslims on the pretext of bhakti?” Vaiṣṇava dāsa Bābājī conducted the debate.

Human beings have only one jāti; castes were devised according to language, country, dress, and complexion, and the jīvas are born into the varṇas according to their karma. Muslims are not eligible for the duties of varṇāśrama, but all human beings are eligible for vaiṣṇava-dharma (Bhagavad-gītā 9.32). The defect of low birth is the fruit of prārabdhakarma, which is destroyed by the name of Bhagavān. Two kinds of activity must be distinguished: vyāvahārika (worldly) and paramārthika (spiritual). Spiritual eligibility does not yet entitle one to certain worldly acts: a caṇḍāla who has taken up hari-nāma does not perform yajñas, but he performs the aṅgas of bhakti, which are infinitely greater.

Eligibility for karma comes from nature and birth; eligibility for bhakti comes only from śraddhā, faith rooted in the Absolute Truth (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 11.20.27–33). Śraddhā is the eternal nature of the jīva; its external symptom is śaraṇāgati with six features: accepting what is favorable, rejecting what is unfavorable, faith in Bhagavān as protector, accepting Him as maintainer, self-surrender, and humility. Śraddhā arises from sukṛti. Nitya-sukṛti, which comes from the association of bhaktas and from devotional activities, yields sādhu-saṅga and bhakti; naimittika-sukṛti from karma, yoga, and jñāna yields enjoyment and liberation. Birth in a Muslim family is the fruit of naimittika-duṣkṛti, faith in ananya-bhakti the fruit of nitya-sukṛti; the one does not depend on the other.

One who has become a Vaiṣṇava is no longer considered a Yavana, and one who judges a bhakta by his birth is destined for hell (Padma Purāṇa). A grhastha Vaiṣṇava should nevertheless observe the duties of his varṇa and marry within it; in ordinary dealings he does not eat with a Vaiṣṇava of Yavana origin, but he should honor prasāda with him. Brāhmaṇas are of two kinds: by nature and by birth only; a pure Vaiṣṇava is a brāhmaṇa from the absolute point of view. Vaiṣṇava dāsa concluded: “Dharma is one, not two, and it is also known as nitya-dharma or vaiṣṇava-dharma. All other forms of naimittika-dharma taught by the Vedas are merely steps leading to this eternal religion.” The paṇḍitas turned pale and the assembly ended.

Chapter 7 – Nitya-Dharma & Material Existence

The miserly merchant Caṇḍīdāsa of Saptagrāma and his wife Damayantī were robbed of their property by their own sons. The couple settled in Kuliyā-grāma, began to live honestly and to serve guests and, following the example of the gr̥hastha-brāhmaṇa Yādava dāsa, the Vaiṣṇavas as well. Caṇḍīdāsa asked: “What is this material existence?” In Pradyumna-kuñja Ananta dāsa Bābājī answered him.

The jīva is either liberated or bound. The bound jīvas have forgotten Kṛṣṇa, and since time without beginning māyā has bound them with the three qualities of nature. In place of the ego of Kṛṣṇa's servant there arises ahaṁtā – “I am a king, a brāhmaṇa, poor” – and mamatā – “my house, my wealth, my children.” The affair set in motion by the conceptions of “I” and “mine” is saṁsāra. The world itself is not false; what is false is this conception, which the jīva adopts in the material world. The jīva stands on the border of both worlds: one who does not forget Kṛṣṇa is drawn into the spiritual realm, and one who turns away is attracted by māyā.

Karma-kāṇḍa, brahma-jñāna, and aṣṭāṅga-yoga are improper means, because material existence arose from an offense, and deliverance can come only by the mercy of the One against whom it was committed. The proper means are sādhu-saṅga and surrender (Bhagavad-gītā 7.14); according to the Prema-vivarta, the only infallible method is to chant kṛṣṇa-nāma in the association of bhaktas. The association of bhaktas is beneficial in every respect; no one should associate with nirbheda Māyāvādīs.

Bhaktas are either householders (gr̥hastha) or renunciants (tyāgī). The gr̥hastha-bhakta subordinates his senses, work, and hospitality to the service of Kṛṣṇa, and his life is a festival of kṛṣṇa-nāma, mercy to the jīvas, and service to the Vaiṣṇavas; for the age of Kali this is the most suitable path, and most of Mahāprabhu's associates were householders. Only one whose tendency is turned completely inward should renounce family life: he has no desire for the opposite sex or for wealth, is merciful to all, and has unconditional love for Kṛṣṇa. Otherwise there is danger of falling down; false renunciation arises from deceit and the desire for prestige. The renunciant lives on alms and does not build monasteries; to sin on the strength of the name is nāma-aparādha. All jīvas have a right to vaiṣṇava-dharma, and therefore it is called jaiva-dharma; the one who has more bhakti is superior. Caṇḍīdāsa understood that the jīva is the eternal servant of Kṛṣṇa who has forgotten this and wears the garland of birth, old age, and death.

Chapter 8 – Nitya-dharma & Vaiṣṇava Behavior

By the pond Śrī Gorā-hrada a young Vaiṣṇava from Baragāchī asked how one who has taken shelter of vaiṣṇava-dharma should behave toward others. The reply came from Haridāsa Bābājī, who was almost a hundred years old. The ten marks of religious life according to Manu (determination, forgiveness, self-control, cleanliness, truthfulness, and others) apply to people in general, but none of them points to hari-bhajana. Those who have accepted the path of bhakti are of three kinds: kaniṣṭha, madhyama, and uttama.

The kaniṣṭha worships the Deity with faith, but does not serve the bhaktas or other beings (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 11.2.47). His faith is customary and his bhakti only a shadow of bhakti; he cannot recognize a true bhakta and behaves toward others according to general moral principles. He advances quickly when the association of bhaktas becomes predominant in his life.

The madhyama Vaiṣṇava (11.2.46) behaves in four ways, which are part of nitya-dharma. He loves Kṛṣṇa with pure bhakti, free from other desires and not covered by jñāna and karma. He is a friend to the pure bhaktas: he associates with them and serves three kinds of Vaiṣṇavas – one who has uttered kṛṣṇa-nāma once, one who chants it constantly, and one whose mere sight inspires others to chant. He is merciful to the ignorant who have not been contaminated by unauthorized doctrines: he awakens their faith and their taste for śrī-nāma and protects them from bad association. And he neglects the inimical – those who do not believe in Īśvara, consider Him a mere force of nature, deny Him form, deny the eternal subordination of the jīvas, or are devoid of mercy. Neglect (upekṣā) does not mean refusing them ordinary social dealings or help in distress, but avoiding their association in spiritual matters.

The uttama-bhakta has attained prema; he sees Kṛṣṇa in all and all in Kṛṣṇa (11.2.45) and does not distinguish between Vaiṣṇava and non-Vaiṣṇava. To consider the level of Vaiṣṇavas and to serve them is therefore the duty of the madhyama; if he neglects it, he becomes an offender. Nityānanda dāsa, who admitted a remnant of desire for honor, was warned by Bābājī that the desire for fame is the most pernicious enemy of the Vaiṣṇavas. One's level is not measured by whether one is a householder or an ascetic, but by one's progress in bhakti. According to Śikṣāṣṭaka (3), one should be free from pride and offer everyone due respect. Other dharmas are either steps toward vaiṣṇava-dharma, to be respected according to their purity, or distortions of it; a Vaiṣṇava should bear no enmity toward their followers. Preaching is a duty, but śrī-kṛṣṇa-nāma is not given to the unqualified.

Chapter 9 – Nitya-dharma, Material Science & civilization

After several years in Śrī Godrūma the heart of Lāhirī Mahāśaya became purified; he understood that what is essential is detachment in the heart, not the external dress of renunciation, and he received the name Advaita dāsa. He was visited by his childhood friend Digambara Caṭṭopādhyāya, a wealthy official, a worshiper of Durgā, and an expert in the tantras. Digambara claimed that the servants of the goddess are more civilized than the Vaiṣṇavas, enjoy the happiness afforded by material science, and that there is no salvation without Mother Nistāriṇī, the primordial power.

Digambara defined civilization as polite speech, respectable dress, and agreeable conduct. Advaita dāsa replied that life is short and the only duty of a human being is to worship Śrī Hari sincerely. The word “civilization” has become a name for polished deceit that conceals depravity; true civilization, free from sin and deceit, consists of truthfulness and simplicity and is found only among the Vaiṣṇavas. The so-called progress of Kali-yuga is merely an increase of sin.

Knowledge is of two kinds: paramāṛthika, concerning eternal truth, and laukika, concerning the transient world. Only the latter is increasing, and with it people neglect spiritual truth. The jīvas are like travelers at an inn; material knowledge should serve only to secure one's livelihood. Military science, medicine, astronomy, and chemistry are all knowledge of material objects, with which the jīva has no eternal connection and which has no significance for his nitya-dharma. Yet the Vaiṣṇavas do not condemn those who strive for material progress: everyone works according to his tendency, and thus the whole world unknowingly serves the Vaiṣṇavas.

Mother Nistāriṇī is viṣṇu-māyā, the external energy of Śrī Hari. Śakti is not an independent object but a power inherent in an object, and she acts according to Bhagavān's desire. Bhagavān has one śakti: on the spiritual plane she is cit-śakti, Rādhikā; on the material plane she is māyā, Durgā; the jīvas are the marginal śakti between them (Bhagavad-gītā 7.4–6). The true śāktas are therefore the Vaiṣṇavas, who are under the shelter of Śrī Rādhikā; those attached only to māyā are merely materialists. Digambara became angry: nothing remains after death, so one should enjoy. Advaita dāsa replied that happiness is peace of mind, and the thirst for enjoyment only grows by enjoying. He had not given up the company of cultured people but gained it; he gives up the company of the fallen, for by associating with them one's good qualities fade (Hari-bhakti-vilāsa). Digambara refused prasāda and took his leave.